

Jessica Colon
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Eyes on the Skies

Across the globe, national cinema functions as a barometer of a population's shared values and experience; it reflects national anxieties, cultural conflict, and has roots in the tradition of utilizing mythology as a means to identify, categorize, contextualize, and manage ideological or intangible threats. Symbolizing the intangible with some "corps" of tangible existence transforms it into something that can now be wholly identified, touched, seen, and eliminated. The established conventions are founded on nationalist storytelling, an indictment of values and heroes, a commentary of collaborative pride, celebration of heterogeneity in some instances, and a framing of ideology and culture in symbolic and relatable terms so that the audience is pulled into the film, and, consequently, connected to their national mythology. American cinema in particular has always been its nation's greatest form of PR in this respect; as self-proclaimed "leaders of the free world", our media offers up heroes who know how to lead, collaborate, overcome, and save the day, no matter the extent of the challenge faced.

As a genre, horror performs multiple societal functions in this regard. The supernatural and ghostly apparitions of the Gothic tradition dangled a social or psychological threat, something in service of harming the morality of intellect of the protagonist. However, by the end of the 1940s, global scientific technology provided a mass horror that exceeded the individual psychology of Gothic horror – the ghosts of the past became increasingly less threatening in the face of real-life horror endured by the United States in the early decades of the 20th century. Starting with the Industrial Revolution, we traversed volatile market fluctuations, two global wars, clandestine forays into nuclear weapons development, spies and foreign interference, ideological threats by way of communism, domestic spies, and political exploitation of

ideological and social fears. Toward the end of the decade, the Soviet Union successfully tested nuclear weapons, adding dimension (and nationalist unity) to the dread. Americans were ripe for paranoia, distrust, and disillusionment toward science, military, and each other, and fear of the future far outranked monsters whose victims could avoid victimhood with just the right amount of morality and sensibility. The new monsters, communism and atomic science, did not care about personal virtue or the individual; they were unknowable, uncontrollable, and uncertain.

Suffice to say, the 1950s were poised to introduce a new American mythology and a genre appropriate to contextualize new fears and offer new terrors. War films and Westerns are as much a part of the fabric of our national identity as the reality upon which they are based, and it's easy to assume that Howard Hawks¹ – an auteur in the nationalist-mythology genres – identified the seed of potential in John Campbell's sci-fi serial "The Thing From Another World". With the future bearing down in the form of violent scientific pursuits, expanded social communities, and labor revolutions, the nostalgic horror of ghosts and the living dead would not have been quite so haunting to a population haunted by the uncertainty of "what if". Still, Hawks references the timeless elements from horror's Gothic ancestors - the abominations of careless science in *Frankenstein* and the abject physical violation of *Dracula* - however, he replaces the damp castles and nostalgia with iconography representative of the future and technology: Geiger counters and mentions of radioactivity, flying saucers (discovered only in 1947), aliens, planes, radios, thermite bombs, and scientific experiments. He inserts additional conflict between two homogenous groups, science and military, and humanity, the ultimate melting pot. He blends genres, layering sci-fi's concern with civilization's survival under the horror's monster, who

¹ Christian Nyby is officially credited as director of this film; however, most of my research indicated that he deferred wholly to Hawks, and most on set felt Hawks was running the show. Given Hawks' overarching involvement as producer and "deferential authority", I felt it was more accurate to cite him as the primary filmmaker, as it seems Nyby was director in name only.

represents an ideological abomination relative to American morality and nature. In this case, he perverts the harmless nature of the vegetable into something sexless, emotionless, blood-hungry, and super-strong, uninterested in compromise or communication, capable of efficient multiplication and invasion, much like an enemy or ideology left to spread unsupervised.

The Thing From Another World was released in 1951 and checks off every box in terms of Cold War allegory – radioactive “other” that suggests threat of foreign invader who seeks to eliminate our physical and metaphysical ways of life, cold and calculating scientists to fan distrust toward the emotionless machinations of science, and a group of diverse American symbols who must unite and lead with ingenuity, collaboration, and strength to save the day. While the genre was dominated by younger audiences, Howard Hawks’ association with the film would have drawn large, diverse audiences; it fared well upon release, garnering about \$1.95 million box office, and was the year’s most popular sci-fi film. It also fed into our national mythology and conspiracy in a way that unites the audience instead of alienating it; Robin Wood suggests that horror supports the status quo – “Normality is threatened by the monster” (Wood, Worland 21), and Hawks takes this approach as a means to enforce American norms and ideals as they are threatened by this foreign invasion. It acknowledged the political paranoia and scientific anxieties in a manner that is not juvenile, mocking, or minimizing; while previous horror tropes would have been safely based on some irrational fear and paranoia, Hawks both validates audiences and breaches the norm of “horror” expectation by isolating his heroes in a harsh, distant environment and overwhelming them with completely rational and timely associations and fears; instead of allowing distance between the audience and film, it identified with the audience’s experiences at the time. It gave a voice to an unsure population by way of Captain Hendry’s team of soldiers, women, scientists, and press, and it gave a physical body to the monster – the body, as referenced by Carrington, operates purely on mindless efficiency and

a singular intent to consume our way of life; a reference to the unfolding capitalist hunger, polarizing pursuits of science in the 1940s, and spread of communism (and, interestingly, it survives the cold quite well – much like those living at Soviet latitudes). The creature is also described as having a “superior brain...not handicapped by emotional or sexual factors”, suggesting a sexless, emotionless, cold, plotting, and logical threat existing solely to oppose Western ideology and humanity. Science is the other major monster bearing down on the times, evidenced by the portrayal of Dr Carrington as a condescending, hyper-logical dictator who makes a greater effort to associate and communicate with the alien at the expense of the human beings at the camp, both directly by endangering their lives by growing the seed pods and indirectly by stealing plasma from the base to feed them. Distrust and unease toward science at the time would be vindicated; by 1951, Americans would have seen evidence of the destructive power of their atomic children, Little Boy and Fat Man, and would be looking to project a sense of nationalist guilt onto a “blame-able” party, i.e. science (projection of guilt being yet another convention of our national cinema). Yet, to a degree, science does save the day in the film, although it is a physical science executed with a trap involving the participation of many members of a diverse group of military, nonscientists, and scientists. It is ultimately a triumph of values, social construct, and behaviors more so than brute strength or pure science; it is a blending of skill and desire by a heterogeneous group in order to preserve their way of life in the face of technological uncertainty and ideological invasion.

Given the freshness of WWII and association with the Korean War, the visibility of military in *The Thing* was certainly a reflection of national expectations and vigilance. Hawks avoids being entirely pro-groupthink, however, by characterizing Captain Hendry as a mindful, charismatic soldier who knows when to listen to his men and when to ignore the chain of command for the benefit of humanity; he welcomes input from his soldiers, playfully engages

with Nikki's bold assertiveness, and has a warm relationship almost instantly with a member of the press, Scotty. His men and Nikki joke about his inevitable court martial at the end of the film, giving audiences a nod that the military itself as a singular entity is no better than the sum of its parts. He even willingly collaborates with the scientists, despite their unwillingness to treat the monster as a threat. His paternalism is indicated by compositions that show him intimately connected to the members of his group. In fact, most compositions that feature human characters are intimate close / medium shots and serve to reinforce the collaborative necessity implicit in their survival. The "Thing" is often in shots alone, although we barely see it at all (and its humanoid form incites an "uncanny valley" sort of unease), heightening its sense of other-ness, and when we see Hendry's men or a scientist alone in a shot, it typically precedes some situation in which the Thing escapes, harms, or causes chaos. Indeed, their survival hinges on an amalgamation of their diverse individual contributions, exceeding the power of strict military brawn and strict scientific logic. They kill it with fire, perhaps an homage to the characteristic burning destruction found in Gothic literature or a general sense of purifying catharsis, although the element of electricity is, once again, embracing the iconography of technology. In any case, if the monster is the physical form of ideological threat, then the Americans' collaboration and determination is the solution.

This unity of heterogeneous knowledge and strength, peppered with charismatic banter and warm characters (with the exception of Carrington, who is still accepted by the group at the end and not reviled or outcast), would have given audiences relief and a sense of safety from the onslaught of topical symbols and iconography; the allegorical and suppositional nature of the threat would have resonated with audiences too well, but Hawks gives Americans a sort of catharsis for the previous decade – a press that is allowed to speak out unhindered by military secrecy, a military captain who values his companions and believes in saving humanity at all

cost, and a post-Rosie-the-Riveter-era strong female like Nikki, eliminating the sense of displacement many would have felt after WWII. Her relationship with Hendry is also a panacea to the “sexless and emotionless” threat of the Thing; it is a heteronormative dance and union, as suggested by the end scenes when they banter about settling down, becoming a direct answer to the Thing’s sexlessness and lack of emotion. The characters are all Realist constructs that symbolize aspects of postwar American life, their behaviors and motivations a reflection of topical issues, lent authenticity by way of humor and bonding or conflict, directly in opposition to the Thing’s way of life.

If Hawks’ answer to the monster – whether symbolic or literal - is American heterogeneity and unity, then it’s possible that his hybridization of popular genres and reinvention of horror as a product of modernity is an extension of that; 1950s audiences encroached the precipice of greater exploration of psyche - monsters like Dracula and Frankenstein were parodied, outgrown, and the real horrors faced were societal, massive, and threatening the moral fabric of civilization as much as the individual. By blending the sociological macro-view of science fiction with the psychological micro-view of horror, and reinterpreting the timeless abjection and hubris of Gothic art’s monsters and scientists, Hawks generates a new heterogeneous mythological construct that works in service of the national cinema’s purpose and evolution. The final scene becomes a newsreel testament to that end; our press man Scotty, framed by his compatriots, announces to the world that while invasion has been stopped, we must look to the sky – or in Hawks’ case, to the future – in vigilance of incoming horror or terror. While audiences would have resonated quite literally with this demand in the years following air drills and two atomic bombs, it interestingly becomes a meta-reflection of the art form itself, a call for humanity to honor the interpretations of past horror while staying cognizant of the horrors yet to come.

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Note:

Aside from just presenting historical context, I was interested in the conflict between culture's interpretation of film as "entertainment" vs its purpose as creating and reinforcing mythologies and norms; especially because horror is often seen as a response to those norms rather than in service of those norms, and its purpose in that regard is linked to the needs of the audience. I felt it was important to include elements of Question 1 because the historical context of this film in particular is directly linked to the evolving collective psychology of the time.

There was SO much more I wanted to discuss but would have exceeded all sane page limits. Plus, so much has already been written about the historical context (and time ran out to submit a draft; hindsight, and all that). Since this was all new to me personally other than the film itself and the Manhattan Project history, I included everything I read as a reference; however, it was difficult to create a "new" thesis given the insane amount of information on the topic. My only other film paper research experience was for Scandinavian cinema, and there's certainly a stark difference in researching cinema from Hollywood vs another corner of the globe – I was prepared to hunt, but ended up with a feast!